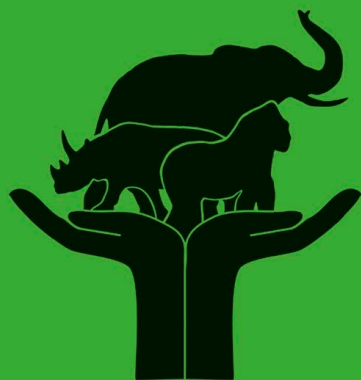




NOTHING IS MORE PRICELESS THAN ANIMAL LIFE

THE ENDANGERED SPECIES ACT (1973)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Environmental law

BEFORE

1900 America's Lacey Act prohibits commercial hunting and interstate trade of certain animals and plants.

1966 The Endangered Species Preservation Act leads to the first list of threatened and endangered species.

1972 The US bans the capture of marine mammals in its waters.

AFTER

1988 Scientists argue that a sixth mass extinction on Earth is underway.

2004 California condors reproduce in the wild for the first time in 17 years.

2007 The bald eagle is delisted following recovery.

2008 The polar bear is listed as threatened due to habitat loss in the Arctic.

The ESA's two aims are to **prevent extinction** and **increase numbers** of endangered species.



Section 4 requires the designation of species as **threatened or endangered**.



If a species is **listed as endangered**, the ESA gives its key habitat **special protection**.



One of the **main threats** to endangered species is the **destruction of their habitat**.

Throughout history, humans have directly caused the extinction of many species of wildlife, such as the dodo, great auk, passenger pigeon, and Tasmanian tiger. Right now, it seems the threat we pose to other animals is accelerating, with 50 percent of species in real danger of disappearing and many biologists talking of extinctions on a massive scale. Hunting is partly to blame, but the principal reason is the loss of natural habitat through farming, deforestation, and urbanization.

Americans began to be aware of the threat to native wildlife in the late 1800s, and in 1900, the US introduced the Lacey Act to ban

trafficking in certain species of wildlife and plants. Originally intended to stop the hunting of wild and game birds and their sale across state lines, today it is used primarily to prevent the importing of invasive species.

The steep rise in human population and activity in the 20th century put many more animals under threat, and by the 1960s, environmental movements were exerting pressure on the US and other governments to act. In 1966, the Endangered Species Preservation Act led to the first list of endangered species, and in 1969, Congress amended the Act to provide additional protection to